Use AI before you need it.

I got laid off, spent five months getting back in, and learned what actually helps. These are the 30 prompts I'd want on day one, sorted by the moment you'll need them.

HOW TO USE THIS KIT

1. Open ChatGPT, Claude or Gemini. The free versions work.
2. Find the moment you're in below, copy the prompt, and replace anything in [brackets] with your details.
3. Paste your own documents where it says [paste]. Remove names and anything confidential first.
4. Never send anything AI wrote without reading it. Never let it invent numbers or facts about you.

WHAT'S INSIDE

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- 2. Severance and benefits
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This kit is general guidance, not legal, financial or medical advice. For your severance agreement, check with HR or an employment lawyer.

1. THE DAY YOU GET THE NOTICE

Sort out your first 48 hours

I was just told my job is being eliminated. My last day is [date]. Make a checklist of what to do in the next 48 hours, in order: what to ask HR before I leave, what to save from my work accounts that I'm allowed to keep, and who to tell first. Keep it to 10 items.

Questions to ask HR before you sign anything

My employer is laying me off. Write 12 clear questions to ask HR about my final pay, unused vacation, health coverage end date, bonus, equity, and reference policy. Group them by topic.

A calm message to your team

Write a short, positive goodbye message to my team. I'm leaving because of a layoff. Thank them, share my personal email and LinkedIn, and keep it under 80 words. No bitterness.

Your money runway in one table

Here are my monthly expenses and savings: [paste]. Build a table showing how many months I can last, which costs I can cut first, and the date I'd need a new paycheck by.

Turn panic into a 2-week plan

I was laid off today. Give me a realistic 2-week plan: one goal per day, nothing bigger than 2 hours, mixing job search, rest and money tasks.

2. SEVERANCE AND BENEFITS

Find everything you can negotiate

Here is my severance letter with names removed: [paste]. List every term I could ask to improve, what's reasonable to ask for, and draft a polite email asking for it. Note anything I should check with HR or an employment lawyer.

Decode the agreement in plain English

Explain this separation agreement in plain English: [paste]. What am I giving up by signing, what are the deadlines, and what does each clause mean for me?

Compare health coverage options

My employer coverage ends on [date]. Compare the general pros and cons of continuing my current plan, joining a spouse's plan, and buying a marketplace plan. Give me the questions to ask each provider.

Ask for a written reference

Write a short, polite email to my manager asking for a written reference or LinkedIn recommendation before my last day. Mention 2 projects: [list].

Track every deadline

From this agreement and these HR emails [paste], list every date and deadline I need to act on, in order, in a table.

3. RESUME

Rewrite your weakest bullet with a number

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Rewrite this as one resume bullet that shows an outcome with a number. If you need a number I didn't give you, ask me. Don't make one up: [bullet]
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Match your resume to a job post

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Here is my resume [paste] and a job posting [paste]. List the 10 most important keywords in the posting and show where my resume covers or misses each one.
```

Cut it to one strong page

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Shorten this resume to one page. Keep the last 10 years, the strongest results, and anything matching [target role]. Tell me what you cut and why.
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Explain a gap or a layoff

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Write one honest line for my resume or cover letter explaining that my role was eliminated in a layoff on [date]. Confident, not defensive.
```

Prove you use AI at work

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Based on my job [describe], suggest 3 honest resume bullets showing how I use AI tools to save time or improve quality. Only use examples I confirm are true.
```

4. LINKEDIN AND OUTREACH

A headline recruiters search for

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Write 5 LinkedIn headline options for a [role] with [X] years in [industry], under 220 characters, using words recruiters search for.
```

An About section in your voice

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Write a LinkedIn About section from my resume [paste]: 3 short paragraphs, first person, one result with a number, and what I'm looking for next.
```

Reconnect without sounding desperate

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Write a short message to a former coworker I haven't talked to in 2 years. Catch up genuinely, mention I'm exploring [role], and ask one easy question.
```

Ask for a referral the right way

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Write a referral request to [name] at [company] for this posting [paste]. Make it easy to say yes: include 3 lines they can forward.
```

Find 20 companies worth targeting

```
I'm a [role] in [location/remote] with skills in [list]. Suggest 20 types of companies or teams likely to hire someone like me, and why each fits.
```

5. INTERVIEWS

Tell me about yourself in 45 seconds

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Write a 45-second answer to 'tell me about yourself': my current role, one result with a number, and why this job. Plain words. My resume: [paste]
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Answer 'why did you leave?'

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Write a short, honest answer to 'why did you leave your last job?' My role was cut in a layoff. Keep it positive and turn it toward what I want next.
```

Predict their questions

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Here's the job posting [paste]. List the 10 questions I'm most likely to be asked, and for each, which story from my resume to use.
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Build STAR stories from your notes

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Turn this messy story into a STAR answer under 90 seconds: [story]. Keep my real details; ask me for anything missing.
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Questions that make you stand out

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Write 6 sharp questions to ask at the end of an interview for [role] at [company], based on this posting [paste].
```

6. PROTECT THE JOB YOU HAVE

Find which parts of your job AI can do

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Split every task in this job description into 3 columns: AI can do it today / AI makes it faster / Still needs a human. Put it in a table: [paste]
```

Messy notes to a status report

```
Turn these notes into a status report with 3 sections: Done, At Risk, Decisions Needed. Under 150 words. Flag anything with no owner or date: [notes]
```

Handle a last-minute request

```
Write a short, friendly reply to this request. Confirm what's due and when, offer two scope options, and ask which matters most: [message]
```

Make your wins visible

```
From this list of what I did this month [paste], write a 5-bullet update for my manager that leads with results and numbers.
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Your 30-day backup plan

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I still have my job but layoffs are rumored. Give me a 30-day plan, 20 minutes a day, to update my resume, LinkedIn, network and savings without anyone noticing.
```

Want this done for your exact job?

The AI Career Firewall Audit: send your resume and LinkedIn, and get back a 1-page layoff-readiness plan plus 5 AI prompts written for your role, within 48 hours. $39.

Get your audit →

New prompts every week: the free prompt library.